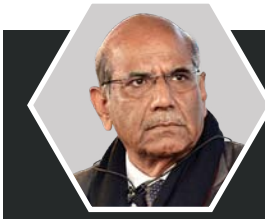
But, as a senior official points out, "Ukraine is Europe's second largest country with a population of 44 million and can't be easily overrun. Putin would have factored in all exigencies, including his opponents' punitive action."

The Russian president thus first took down Ukraine's air defence system with a series of missile strikes, gaining dominance of the skies. Simultaneously, he sent troops to secure Donetsk and Luhansk—regions that would help him gain a partial land corridor to Crimea. Next, he focused on Kharkiv, Ukraine's second largest city, where he blew up key government buildings, gaining a semblance of control. (It was in this assault that Indian student Naveen S.G. was killed along with other Ukrainian civilians.) Simultaneously, Russian troops laid siege to Kyiv, encircling it from three sides, with satellite pictures showing a 60-km-long line of tanks and armoured vehicles moving towards the capital. In line with Putin's calculations and much to Zelensky's dismay, no country, including the US, was willing to put boots on the ground or take on the Russian armed forces directly.

What Putin perhaps did not expect was the stringent economic sanctions Europe, the US and Japan would retaliate with. Strongest among the measures was cutting off several key Russian banks from SWIFT, the global messaging service for financial transactions, which put instant pressure on Moscow. Raghavan calls it "the financial equivalent of pressing the nuclear button, rarely employed". The European response too was a united, cohesive one, as country after country instituted measures that promised to go well beyond immediate economic sanctions.

As Emmanuel Lenain, the French ambassador to India, points out, "there was a gross miscalculation on Putin's part—he was expecting Europe to be disunited and instead found the opposite. A strong united front emerged, especially on defence". He adds, "Importantly, European countries like Germany are now joining France in spending two per cent of their GDP on defence, apart from supplying significant arms to help Ukraine resist the invasion. With the sanctions, we have made life difficult for Russia and that impact is visible in the Russian rouble sinking by a margin of 30 per cent. It shows that sanctions are biting." But sanctions could hurt Europe too, as many countries depend on Russia for their energy needs (Germany imports 60 per cent of its gas from it), besides other major commodities, culminating in inflationary trends.



SHYAM SARAN
Former foreign secretary

> "The US identifying Russia as its main adversary instead of China will affect Quad, of which India is a part"



BALA VENKATESH VARMA
Former Indian ambassador to Russia

> "If we commit to either side, it'll be like issuing a blank cheque they'd cash on with no guarantee for our concerns"

INDIA'S TIGHTROPE WALK

When the invasion began, the immediate worry for India was the evacuation of the 20,000-plus students in various universities in Ukraine. That mission acquired fresh urgency after a student was killed in the Russian bombardment of Kharkiv. "Our foremost priority," foreign secretary Harsh Shringla admitted, "was to get our citizens, especially students, out of the conflict zone and we put all our equities in that direction. In the meanwhile, we advocated diplomacy and dialogue to solve issues and refrain from hostilities. We kept our lines of communication open with all parties involved." The Modi government launched a massive evacuation programme, Operation Ganga, setting up 24x7 control centres, pressing Indian airliners to send out special flights and deploying four Union ministers as special envoys to key neighbouring countries to coordinate the efforts. By March 1, over 9,000 students had been evacuated and most of the others had been moved out of the conflict zones.

Then there was the diplomatic tightrope India had to walk on the invasion itself. It found itself somewhat in the same position as when Russia invaded Afghanistan in 1979—sure enough, India abstained from condemning it this time too. Then, as now, India remains highly